

Foundational FSL

Project: four-square-letterhead.ai. Method/contract edition: v1.10. Four-Square Template v1.10. Release edition. Project adoption remains separate.

This Markdown owns the method; PDF/DOCX are derived views. FSL forms and maintains agreements; each project establishes its own DNA in SPEC.

1. Documents govern; stewardship maintains continuity

Adopted documents hold the agreement

Adopted FSL documents are the **single source of truth for its agreed business and technical intent**: purpose, scope, commitments, responsibilities and contracts. FSL serves business, operations, software, hardware, data and English deliverables. Documents state the agreement; evidence establishes observed outcomes.

Experience informs the maintenance skill's questions, reviews and proposals. A skill, agent or MEMORY **MUST NOT** silently create, reinterpret or override adopted requirements. Changing contributors, tools or skills does not change the contract. **Documents govern. Skills maintain. Evidence verifies.**

Name responsibility; do not infer authority

A **steward** keeps documents, work, evidence and decisions understandable together. An observer reports; a steward maintains and proposes; an executor works within scope; the named decision authority approves intent. These are responsibilities, not new squares or compulsory job titles. One person may perform several; an agent needs explicit delegation. Stewardship is ongoing responsibility, not an installed monitor or schedule.

Record who can approve which decision and where that authority comes from. Authorship, repository access, assignment, silence or a previous unrelated approval is not permission. Intent approval, execution/spending permission and release acceptance are separate decisions. Unclear or expired authority pauses the dependent action; safe, unaffected work may continue. Do not require separate people unless the project's controls do.

One entry point; four continuing responsibilities

Put **FSL first inside SPEC**, followed by adopted scope, rules, contracts, acceptance and routes. Use one repository or several coordinated repositories; name the entry point and authoritative revisions. Every material artifact **SHOULD** have one authoritative home; references and generated views are not competing originals.

Start with [**SPEC | SYSTEM | AI | MEMORY**]. SPEC and MEMORY stay fixed; SYSTEM and AI are recommended defaults with justified alternatives. SPEC owns adopted intent; SYSTEM owns deliverables and checks; AI owns AI-specific operating intelligence where relevant; declare inactivity when unused; MEMORY retains rationale, continuity and evidence links but cannot establish Project DNA. **Squares own artifacts; routes cross only the artifacts needed for the claimed outcome.** They are continuing responsibilities, not phases. Ownership follows purpose, not authorship. FSL retains TEMPLATES / SKILL; project work stays in its declared repositories.

Formation, sister cells and advancement

FSL-FORM-001. Foundational FSL is a provider-neutral formation and stewardship method beyond Skill use. A **Project Cell** is one governed expression. SPEC carries **Project DNA**: adopted intent and authority for continuity, variation and advancement. Execution belongs in delivering squares. Skills **MUST NOT** silently alter DNA or assume evolution authority.

FSL-LINE-002. Projects **MAY** create **Sister Cells** from an identified DNA baseline for a declared purpose. Each **MUST** preserve lineage and separate state/evidence. Retain scoped contracts, skills, references and constraints. Permissions, acceptance, release approval, another cell's PASS and later changes never transfer automatically. Re-establish affected environment, access, state, assumptions and proof; reuse evidence only where its recorded scope applies.

FSL-ADV-003. Variation creates candidates. Evidence describes candidates. Authority selects advancement. SPEC names who may vary, compare, select and adopt, with bounds. Selective, exploratory, comparative, mixed and fixed advancement are examples, not a schema. Bounded randomness **MAY** propose permitted variation; it **MUST NOT** constitute approval. A sister cell **MUST NOT** silently become the parent. Promotion requires an explicit authorized decision and recorded baseline.

Plain English, one authoritative meaning

The optional appendix explains without creating authority or proof. Use one editable source per document. Start with one page; the letterhead maximum is three, with unrestricted supporting records. Remove duplication before shrinking type. No compulsory forms, route tables, YAML schema or iteration ledger.

Separate project/contract from method/template identity on every page. **MUST** / **MUST NOT** bind; **SHALL** / **SHALL NOT** are aliases. **SHOULD** / **SHOULD NOT** guide; **MAY** permits. Labels alone set no force. Render normative words in capitals, bold and underline. Keep stable clause IDs with baseline context; never recycle them for unrelated obligations. Binding intent **MUST NOT** be silently weakened.

FSL owns the method. The project owns the work.

2. Work in focused rounds; verify meaningful paths

Routes define coverage; iterations organize work

Use **R-01: input** → **required touchpoints** → **observable output**. State outcome, exclusions, clauses and baseline; identify material conditional, asynchronous and midpoint boundaries. Add routes for distinct important paths. Touchpoints are not branches; never delete a failing point to manufacture success.

Route defines expected coverage; run records observed coverage. An iteration is one focused round of work and learning, possibly with several runs. Several iterations may improve one route. No compulsory I-numbering. Close with the result and unresolved work.

New work grows; existing work adopts the present

New projects **SHOULD** begin with four E2E learning goals: **tiny complete path** → **useful behavior** → **boundary/recovery** → **intended-use rehearsal** → **grow**. Repeat or split goals; explain material departures. These are not four compulsory iterations, routes or release approval. Preserve proven behavior unless reviewed intent changes it.

Existing systems may study or reverse-engineer a reviewed present baseline, separate observed behavior from adopted intent, disclose gaps and verify important routes. An old bug is not law. Historical and future iteration plans are optional. Do not reconstruct early loops, rebuild working capability or rewrite history for adoption.

Collaborate close to the work

Prefer local tools, human judgment and bounded agent help. Minimize unnecessary changes, calls, delay, cost and coordination without weakening required controls or route coverage. A task identifies goal, baseline, route, scope, owner and expected result; return changes, evidence, limits and next decision there. Checklist-based work is recommended, not compulsory forms.

GitHub Projects/Issues, Codex and pull requests are optional adapters. Assignment is not execution; confirm receipt and result. Agents stay within granted scope. Background work needs identifiable progress, cancellation and a final receipt; this method starts none. Do not invent an integration or delegate approval implicitly.

Actions stay off; approval has a budget

GitHub Actions are OFF by default, including FSL's development and releases. Agents **MUST NOT** enable, start or retry them without explicit, scoped user approval. Suggest a justified run and wait. A general develop, commit or release request is not permission. Inspect triggers before remote writes; pause writes that could cause unapproved starts. Do not silently change settings.

Estimate starts, jobs/downstream work, status reads, result fetches, duration and cost or uncertainty. Recommend zero starts when local work suffices; otherwise propose **one start per rolling 60 minutes**, with an explicit task total and expiry. Two per hour needs justification and approval. These are ceilings, not standing permission, schedules or targets.

Name the counted unit. Charge each start attempt, retry and downstream execution to its allowance, including failed, cancelled or uncertain attempts. Cap jobs and runner time; one dispatch is not unlimited work. Estimate and cap reads separately; an all-calls cap includes them. Share the budget across the named repositories and agents through one accountable dispatcher and checkable receipts. Unknown consumption means pause.

No tight polling or blind timeout retries. Stop at any cap or expiry; re-estimate and seek an extension before exceeding scope, counts or cost. Time passing does not renew expired approval. A required unapproved gate remains blocking and **NOT YET PROVEN**. OFF is policy, not a claim that remote settings or hourly enforcement were configured.

Check the declared route, not a convenient substitute

Show every touchpoint before a run; retain PASS, FAIL or NOT RUN, including unreached points. Record revision, baseline, environment, substitutions, outcome and evidence in ordinary logs or prose. Never prefill PASS. Component success **MUST NOT** be called integrated E2E proof.

Unchanged components can participate without edits. Stubs prove only their disclosed boundary. Include AI only when the runtime claim depends on it. E2M/M2E stay partial until integrated; parallel paths retain their results and check shared state. Expected rejection can PASS a negative route. Prefer safe representative checks over destructive production tests.

3. Surface drift; resolve decisions; preserve the record

Compare intent with reality without guessing

At adoption, material change, handover or release, the steward **SHOULD** compare documents, work/practice and evidence. **Drift is a mismatch, not permission to rewrite the agreement.** State expected/observed behavior, baseline/route, evidence, impact and decision owner. Distinguish confirmed mismatch from suspicion or missing proof. No monitor or automatic external call is required.

Repair implementation within scope for unchanged intent; correct stale summaries without editing released originals. Propose adoption for changed intent. Keep uncertain intent, authority, evidence or compatibility explicit; invent neither precedence, approval nor success. Pause dependent claims/actions; continue only safe, unaffected work. Resolve through authorized decisions, affected checks and evidence, not merely a closed task.

Leave a useful current view, not a dashboard

Keep a dated baseline, routes, claims, gaps, drift and **next decision with its owner**, linking evidence/approvals. Missing owners stay unassigned. Support handover without the original chat; keep updates outside frozen documents.

Older evidence retains its original scope, not automatic applicability after change. Assess reuse; recheck affected boundaries. A scoped review may conclude no change is needed. No ceremonial edits are required.

Copies, forks, deployments and handovers are different events. Identify origins, changes and applicable evidence. Ancestry grants no current approval or execution permission. Different forms are drift only when they violate adopted promises in scope.

FSL-ADV-003 continued. Before promotion, review parent DNA, affected routes and evidence. Selection is not merge-by-default. Combining sister-cell variations creates a new candidate with identified contributions; it **MUST NOT** inherit combined approvals or assume separate checks prove the combination. Check shared boundaries and affected behavior. Promotion under unchanged DNA records delivery; only explicit Adoption of a SPEC revision creates a new DNA **Generation**.

Improve the skill; reuse what is proven

Version skills separately; learning does not adopt intent. For English work, **brief** → **sources** → **interpretation** → **draft** → **review** → **delivery** tests fidelity, usability and uncertainty. One example proves no universal reliability. Analogies and homologies explain structural correspondences: route as map, run as journey. Metaphors create neither authority nor proof.

Name essential technologies/libraries/references with purpose/source; pin material versions. REUSE uses capability; INHERIT adopts a contract; REFERENCE consults without adopting law. Binding choices need clauses. Evaluate proven work before rebuilding; inventories stay outside. Add optional process only for understanding, coordination, evidence or release confidence; never waive binding controls.

Amend intentionally; retain the released baseline

Review drafts directly; appendices may grow during discovery. Preserve released SPEC. **Appendix explains; errata corrects without changing intent; an adopted amendment changes intent.** These are optional documents, not required stages or folders. Intent-changing corrections need amendments.

A proposal is not approval. Adoption names authority, affected documents/baseline and clauses, exact change, effective scope/date and immutable record. Resolve overlapping changes before conformance claims. Reassess implementation, routes and evidence: approved intent is not implemented or verified behavior. The next release **SHOULD** incorporate applicable adopted corrections/amendments without altering earlier baselines.

Review the compatible combination and scoped result

Preserve history: main1 is its original first commit; new lanes start there. Existing systems may adopt a reviewed present baseline. Later lanes continue matching predecessors; suffixes follow project releases. main is accepted integration. Validate scope/dependencies; never fabricate history or move roots.

Review stable SPEC, verified deliverable, aligned second concern or inactivity, and understandable MEMORY. Record four reviewed commits/integration, or authoritative paths/revisions and compatible combined baseline across repositories. Check shared route boundaries. Squares need not be repositories; commits identify snapshots, branch names alone do not. **One version, four squares, all green** is not a demand for CI.

Scope proof as **CLAIM / SCOPE / ENVIRONMENT / EVIDENCE / RESULT**. Missing evidence or unresolved intent is **NOT YET PROVEN**; a known binding violation is **NON-CONFORMANT** in the affected scope.

CONFORMANT requires applicable evidence without unresolved violations. **CONFORMANT WITH EXCEPTION** needs authorized scope, clause, reason, evidence and review/expiry. A waiver cannot turn an unrun check into PASS.

Distinguish drafted, reviewed, tested, accepted and published. Local packaging is not publication; a public branch is not a Releases-page entry. Framework publication certifies no consuming project. MEMORY may preserve Project DNA; MEMORY cannot establish it.

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